DEFENDER GUIDE TO RELATIONSHIPS

Enhance romantic partnerships, friendships, and parent-child relationships

16Personalities

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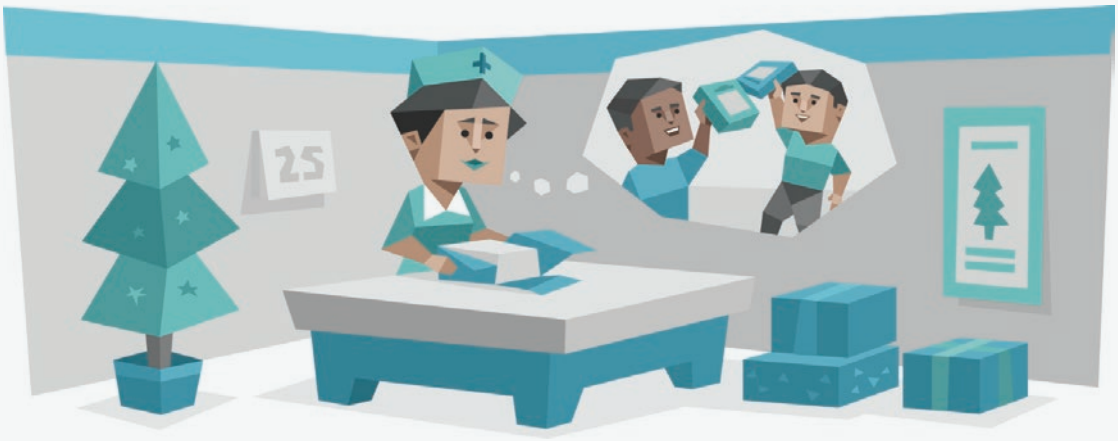


Introduction

Why Relationships Matter for Defenders

Defenders may be Introverted, but they feel happiest when they build a solid community around themselves. Few things matter more to people with this personality type than ensuring that their relationships remain healthy and strong. Whether in their families, their friendships, or their romantic lives, they spend much of their time quietly working to foster a peaceful, harmonious environment – not just for their own benefit, but also for the people who matter to them.

For Defenders, life isn't about huge, earth-shaking events but rather the happy little moments of connection that each day brings: sharing a smile with a loved one, bringing homemade soup to a sick friend, or surprising an aging relative with a visit. Individually, these moments may seem small, but over time, Defenders prove themselves to be among the most devoted friends, family members, and romantic partners to be found.

All that Defenders ask is that their kindness is repaid with acknowledgment and their devotion repaid with loyalty. But that isn't always what happens. At times, Defenders may find themselves carrying more than their own weight in their relationships – and even if they say nothing out loud, they may become quietly discouraged or resentful.

In these pages, we'll discuss how Defenders can bring the full range of their gifts to their relationships – including their romantic relationships, their friendships, and, if they have children, their roles as parents. We'll also discuss how Defenders can restore balance when they find

themselves feeling underappreciated, neglected, or misunderstood by the people they care about. Along the way, Defenders will be equipped with insights and strategies to help them build the lasting, steadfast, heartfelt relationships that – as they well know – make life all the sweeter.

Curious about the traits that make up your personality type and the theory behind them? You can learn more here.

Romantic Relationships

"Home" is a powerful concept for Defenders, and romantic partners personify "home" for these types, even if their relationships haven't yet advanced to living together. From new regular dating partners to spouses, steady love interests can reinforce the sense of familiarity and predictability that's so satisfying to them. Some other personality types may worry whether they can stay with the same people all their lives. Defenders, on the other hand, typically crave longevity. It may be challenging to find many types more loyal in love than they are.

However, it would be a mistake to oversimplify Defenders' loyalty as a need to sustain emotional or material security. Their commitment comes from their drive to care for someone else. When they fall in love, they don't think of opportunity. Instead, they're likely to emphasize the traditional "two become one." They merge beyond mere usefulness. Their beloveds enter Defenders' sphere of nurturing and become integral parts of their lives. It's a grave matter, and this may be clear from the first inkling that they're entertaining romantic feelings.

True partnerships form within the seriousness nature of relationships, and Defenders do all they can to keep them safe. This doesn't mean such relationships are invulnerable. They can still succumb to the things that destroy couples. However, their romantic relationships are unlikely to crumble because Defenders fail to apply effort. Once in love and committed to others, these types usually intend to stay for the long haul.

Dating and the Single Defenders

Young Defenders view dating as a rite of passage. If someone attracts

them romantically, the attraction is usually sparked by their getting to know their potential partners beforehand. "Love at first sight" can happen, but it's more likely Defenders connect with love interests in more deliberate ways. Potential candidates are found in familiar places where they can first become acquainted with them casually – perhaps at work or school. They prefer traditional dating practices and venues. They may enjoy dancing at the prom or a local club, going to the movies, or experiencing some other time-honored dating custom. Novelty isn't necessary. While spontaneity can be fun for Defenders, they're more at home with planned activities.

Even during the dating phase, Defenders are giving individuals. The first hint that their focus involves taking care of those they love appears very early, and they tend to bend over backward to please the people they go out with. Early on, they try to guarantee their dates have an enjoyable evening.

However, this only goes so far. If these types feel that anyone they go out with is too spontaneous – perhaps so much so that Defenders interpret it as irresponsibility – they may shut down. They need structure, and they need rules. Not everyone they date may embrace their strict codes, but those not adhering to protocol during their shared evenings may give a false impression. Judging them so harshly can eliminate otherwise perfectly good romantic partners for Defenders.

Fear may also come into play when Defenders' dates behave too far afield of what they're accustomed to, or suggest activities outside of their comfort zones, as these may leave them feeling abandoned. If their companions don't create ways to include them, or Defenders don't jump in themselves (which may be uncharacteristic), these budding relationships may turn into disappointments. Engaging Defenders' practical and organizational skills may give them a way to be a part of such activities (or for them to include themselves). For example, a music festival may not be Defenders' first choice of activities, but involving them in preparing and planning such an outing may appeal to their logistical bent if they can help book lodging, plan menus, develop a timetable, or arrange transportation to and from the venue. Such involvement may help Defenders discover a niche in even the most unfamiliar activities.

Early dating may feel like checking off the "cultural" and "life stages" boxes for many Defenders. However, as time goes on, dating does become serious business for these types. Family and other close affiliations are essential to them. Dating is part of the usual path to settling down, and since it's such a serious matter, they may do whatever they can to keep their relationships intact. For their well-being, they may want to balance preserving their dreams and desires against putting their energy into pleasing their potential lovers.

If they abandon their needs in pursuit of romance, Defenders may only feel unfulfilled in their relationships. Taken to the extreme, though, this can lead to deeper despair – and finding indirect and unhealthy ways to deal with their unhappiness. For Defenders, this can involve becoming uncharacteristically uncooperative, depressed, and sullen. These indirect protest measures serve as attempts to spotlight their dissatisfaction without being directly confrontational. Finding more direct means to advance their causes and romantic needs may be a challenge Defenders need to revisit again and again.

Defenders in the Bedroom

Defenders' natural impulse to care for others and giving natures can motivate them to be generous lovers who extend their nurturing selves into their sex lives. However, this isn't to say Defenders are bold or experimental in the bedroom. They're mostly reserved, but they want to satisfy their partners and give themselves to the extent they can while staying within their boundaries. They're also likely to take sex seriously. When in relationships, the concept of commitment – each giving themselves to the other – is firmly ingrained somewhere in Defenders' consciousness during sex.

However, these types should exercise caution to avoid putting their partners' sexual needs and desires exclusively ahead of their own. While doing so might work temporarily, in time, their giving without receiving satisfaction in return may reduce lovemaking to a chore for them. It can rob the experience of its depth and meaning. Also, Defenders' generous nature may create conflict if their partners show an interest in experimenting, as many couples do to keep their sex lives fresh. Depending on the cultural and traditional mores they identify with, Defenders may define "acceptable" sexual behavior more

narrowly than other types might. If this is the case, feeling pressure to experiment won't work for many Defenders.

Learning to communicate honestly about sexual matters may be essential for these types, but it may never be easy for them to be forthcoming with their feelings. Defenders might offer suggestions that allow their lovers to hear their needs and respond accordingly. They may try "I feel..." statements – for example, "I feel sad when you rush and don't take your time." There may be a point where counselors, therapists, or religious counselors might be helpful if partners feel their needs aren't met.

Breaking Up is Hard to Do

With the strong Judging trait comes a desire for a sense of steadiness and predictable forward movement. For these types, a surprise breakup is the ultimate assault. It derails everything they think about relationships and turns their worlds upside down. While such disruption isn't unique to Defenders, they take it more to heart than many other personality types. A love affair that's falling apart robs them of their deep desire for connectedness.

If Defenders see an inevitable end coming, they may terminate a romance, even though it violates a vital core goal in their lives. Such breakups might fall under "living effectively." Despite the pain and profound sense of loss, these types may judge it as the best thing they can do for themselves or their partners. They're unlikely to try to hold unhappy partners in relationships if they're determined to go. Even in love, practical realism is likely to win out for Defenders.

However, in some cases, Defender lovers may protect relationships long after they should be allowed to wind down. The loyalty that serves them so well in most aspects of their lives can keep them from ending troubled relationships. If there's a glimmer of hope, they may try to hang on. Defenders may come to a juncture where they need to decide if they're loyal for loyalty's sake or if there's something in their relationships that truly earn their devotion.

As hokey as the advice is after a breakup, recommending they "get back on the horse" may be just the thing for Defenders. Returning as soon

as they can to the familiarity of being in a committed relationship may provide healing and a healthy refuge for them. Defenders learn the lessons of having their hearts broken as most do, but breakups do little to alter their core characteristics. Change comes, but their hopes and expectations remain the same and continue to guide them through their lives. Defenders tend to accept that heartbreak can be painful but is rarely fatal, and sometimes it opens the way for more suitable romances.

Potential Role Pairings

Each Role contains a set of four personality types that share core characteristics and, therefore, are similar to each other. Exploring the Roles and their potential romantic interactions with Defenders can provide a helpful framework for navigating relationships. However, some caution is warranted. Life is messy and full of hard decisions. People aren't like puzzle pieces that fit other pieces in some perfect, predictable way. Too many variables affect all relationships.

Traits may manifest in distinct or obvious ways, but sometimes they're a subtle undercurrent of someone's personality. Often traits become subdued over time, or exaggerated, as people adapt to societal and other pressures. When considering traits, too rigid an interpretation of another's tendencies can confine romantic partners into identities that don't fit. A more reasonable goal is to discover how traits might influence each unique partner within a couple. In loving relationships, personal conversations outdo even the most reliable personality studies.

Although the information provided here can help readers navigate relationships better, we won't pretend to offer exact solutions, nor predict perfect romantic partners through personality types alone. However, the information provided by personality types can be a powerful tool for romantic exploration, especially in creating deeper understanding and meeting each other's needs – and like any tool, it's best used with education, patience, and practice.

Defender–Analyst Relationships

For distinct reasons, both Defenders and Analysts seek longevity in romantic relationships. Defenders want to make a real or metaphorical sense of "home" that serves as a bulwark against the chaos and unpredictability of the outside world. Analysts tend to cherish long-term loving partners because both interpreting and expressing emotions is confusing and challenging work for them. Finally finding others to love who "makes sense" to them is rare, and these individuals are to be treasured and sustained. Defenders' and Analysts' sense of loyalty is a solid match, albeit for distinct reasons.

Balanced Defender–Analyst Relationships

Love and the Mental Checklist

Defenders and Analyst are both likely to approach finding lovers with some degree of calculation. Both types carry a checklist either in their conscious or subconscious mind, ticking off items as they explore potential romantic candidates. In fact, it wouldn't be surprising if either type developed a written list of the qualities they're seeking in a love interest.

For Defenders, their items match their cultural standards, traditions, and mores. Analysts have uniquely rational reasons, and their lists are customized accordingly. Neither type is likely to be vague about their preferences and needs in their relationships. This surety can set up a solid foundation that potentially feeds into the strength of these couples. While they may formulate their searches differently, both Defenders and Analysts approach romantic relationships with a sense of certainty – and even a sense of mission.

Love and Efficiency

Although they might express it differently, both these partner types share a sense of effectiveness. For Defenders, it's more real-time, real-world, and logistic – their purpose is to ensure things remain hassle-free, accurate, and safe. For Analysts, efficiency concerns more theoretical yet elegant solutions. Their aim is to discover innovative ways to perfect systems and procedures. If these partners gain respect for the others' strengths, they can evolve into formidable couples, indeed.

Analysts may impress Defenders with their serious nature and intelligent manner. Defenders may find Analysts' penchant for treating life as a puzzle to solve as interesting and even exciting – but only if it's not overdone. Since Analysts "make sense," Defenders may see this as stability, and little is more attractive to these types than stability. In return, Analysts tend to appreciate Defenders' ability to counter chaos with thoroughness, and are smitten by their decisiveness and sense of order, among other unique qualities. For Analysts, particularly those having the Prospecting trait, Defenders may fill in disorganized gaps in their lives.

Unbalanced Defender–Analyst Relationships

Conflicting Sense of Satisfaction

When one partner type seeks harmony and predictability, and another always questions the status quo with an eye toward making things better, it can lead to unsettled feelings. Therein lies a potential problem when Defenders and Analysts fall in love. Defenders find satisfaction in being anchored and well-defined. Analysts find it in exploring different perspectives and possibilities.

When it comes to these matters, Analysts with the Judging trait may come closer to Defenders' sensibilities. Nonetheless, their Intuition still has them searching the universe for possibilities – just not as many as their Prospecting counterparts. Defenders who labor to build stable, predictable homes and lives may become flummoxed when their partners seem to be looking for something more. It may be as simple as Defenders wanting to keep their current mortgages while their Analyst partners search for ways to refinance. Or they might not see eye-to-eye regarding major lifestyle decisions. For example, do they send the

children to traditional public or private schools, or look for alternative academic possibilities that might be more interesting?

Defenders likely want to stay with what they know and become concerned when their Analyst partners try to open the spectrum of possibilities. These types are happy with settling down, routine, and certainty. They may interpret their Analyst partners' looking beyond their psychological "nests" as a sign of discontent. It can be worrisome for them and cause tension in their love lives.

Seeking Solutions in Different Ways

Where Defenders see one tried and true way of doing something, Analysts explore alternatives because they believe there may be many solutions to the same problem. It's not that Defenders' proven methods aren't enough, it's that Analysts seek to stretch their understanding and exercise their imagination to discover more options. For example, using the phone to change an insurance policy may be Defenders' preferred method to handle the task. It's likely what they're accustomed to, and they may regard it as an uncomplicated, direct solution.

Analysts, however, might focus on the insurance company's website as being more efficient. They may cite the ability to make the change online without being put on hold to wait for an operator, their having more control over the information they enter, and their ability to make the change at their convenience. Defenders want to complete tasks in ways that are familiar to them. Analysts also seek to complete tasks, only in an optimized fashion. It's possible neither approach is necessarily wrong. They're just different. If either of these types demand the other does something exclusively according to their preferred method, it can bring tension to their relationships.

These differences may also extend to moral or other important decisions. For Defenders, these answers are black and white because they base their methods on codes and admonitions they were brought up with. Meanwhile, Analysts untie complicated ethical knots created mostly on the theoretical whiteboard in their minds, causing Defenders to become impatient. "The answer is clear. What's the holdup?" may be their Defender lovers' refrain.

To further complicate the decision-making process, Defenders are more prone to conclusions that promote the welfare of others and strive to maintain harmony. Analysts may see emotional considerations as inefficient or "fuzzy thinking," preferring instead to adopt more straightforward strategies heavily reliant on bare facts. They may not always consider the emotional costs and the importance of heeding others' opinions. It may upset Defenders when their beloveds offer suggestions that appear "cold" to them.

Focusing When Priorities Are Out of Sync

Those with the Observant trait and those with the Intuitive trait bring their worlds into focus in unique ways. While Intuitive Analysts pay attention to details in support of larger concepts, Observant Defenders keep their worlds in place by focusing on specific details that they can appropriately arrange. It's not so much that Analysts ignore similar details. They can be very detailed-oriented if it matches their priorities. However, what is important to Defenders may not be important to Analysts, and vice versa.

As an example, leaving the cap off the toothpaste might go unnoticed by some Analysts, particularly if their minds are elsewhere. If a replaced toothpaste cap represents order to Defenders, however, they may feel Analysts don't have respect for their standards. Such matters may seem trivial to Analysts, but not all "trivial" things are meaningless to everyone. It's a question of focus and context.

By the same token, Analysts may go too deeply "into the weeds" on issues that are important to them, but leave Defenders shrugging their shoulders. To Analysts, larger concepts are important. Theories, often supported by specialized details, help organize their lives. However, if these aren't concrete or practical, they can wear on Defenders' patience. They may labor to keep day-to-day details in order while Analysts go on about theories they feel are annoyingly irrelevant and unhelpful.

Occasional occurrences of out-of-sync priorities may not matter much, but repeated and constant instances create tension. If these couples fail to respect each others' differences, these differences may transform into their relationships' defining identities. Incompatibility bears responsibility for many a failed relationship.

Rebalancing Defender–Analyst Relationships

Remembering Why They Fell in Love

Marriage counselors often find couples forget who it was they married. Sure, they get the names and the faces straight, but they seem to forget they once adored – or at least accepted – the qualities that so irritate them now. It's unrealistic to commit to relationships believing their partners can someday change, and it may be important they remember who they fell in love with in the beginning.

In Defender–Analyst relationships, Defenders came in with all the strengths and weaknesses typical of their personality type. The same applies to Analysts. Communication can be hard for Defenders who fear making waves. Analysts, who are uncomfortable exploring their feelings, may also be reluctant. But Defenders, in all their reticence, aren't afraid of hard work. Whenever differences in personality styles seem overwhelming, it may help to remember what drew these couples together in the first place. Here's an exercise these couples can try to help them do this.

- Listing these formerly appreciated qualities and sharing them can become a powerful anniversary ritual.
- This ritual can also serve as emergency "first aid" whenever Defenders and Analysts discover they're getting on each other's nerves.
- If their communication breakdown is severe enough, finding a professional – a counselor, a therapist, or a religious leader – may make talking about delicate matters easier.

It's important for Defender and Analyst couples to remember that because they may have different approaches, neither is necessarily more correct than the other. Once they appreciate there are methods other than their own, they may even try to dip their toes a bit into their partners' ponds. Defenders may enjoy playing with ideas their Analyst partners bring them and may find doing so useful for broadening their insights. Analysts who explore Defenders' priorities (which don't seem important on most days) may learn they have intriguing qualities when given proper attention. Even if Defenders don't fully embrace the ways of their Analyst lovers, or Analysts the ways of Defenders, appreciating the value of what they do can enhance their overall appreciation of each other.

Defender–Diplomat Relationships

Defenders and Diplomats have a great many things in common. Both have an interest in nurturing others. Both regard loyalty as noble. Defenders create a stable environment where the people they love thrive. Diplomats have an interest in supporting the mental and spiritual growth of others. Both types stand firm after they've adopted a standard as their own. Even though they develop their standards in different ways, both hold a high regard for the values they embrace. And both vigorously seek to be instrumental in creating harmony.

Balanced Defender–Diplomat Relationships

A Little Heaven and a Little Earth: A Potentially Good Mix

Defenders ground their Diplomat partners, who may at times be flighty and idealistic, especially if they have the Prospecting trait. Diplomats, on the other hand, invite the Defenders they love to spread their imaginative wings and dream a little. When Defenders become stressed and overloaded, Diplomats can help them find larger, perhaps more fanciful priorities to tie their kites to. They demonstrate that the daily grind isn't everything. Meanwhile, Diplomats typically need to connect more to that very daily grind. Where they might otherwise avoid life's mundane details, their Defender lovers can anchor them to the everyday things that they must attend to.

When they first begin to date, Defenders may be impressed with the degree to which Diplomats care about the well-being of others. Defenders tend to impress Diplomats with their ability to care for others on a more practical level, and they may see Defenders' approach as supplementing their own more spiritual, social, and psychological

growth focus. In time, Diplomats are likely to reveal themselves to be hot air balloons drifting in the ether, and Defenders can become the mooring lines that keep these couples attached to reality. Meanwhile, Defenders tend to enjoy the view from the heavens that Diplomats offer.

Values: Different, but the Same

When Defender–Diplomat couples take the time to understand each other, there are unlikely to be more caring couples. While they may arrive at their values differently, they're both values-based types. While Defenders uphold values from their communities, upbringing, or tradition, and Diplomats from concepts and philosophical exploration, they are, nonetheless, both bound to ethics. If they avoid focusing on how each acquired their morals and instead appreciate their shared intent to nurture the people on their radars, such couples can connect in ways that radiate selflessness.

Unbalanced Defender–Diplomat Relationships

The Practical Will Always Test the Ideal

Much can be made concerning practical Defenders and their idealistic Diplomat sweethearts balancing each other. It's a wonderful thing... until it isn't. These partnerships don't always unfold as expected. At first, Defenders may find Diplomats' utopian inclinations interesting and attractive. Diplomats' focus on values appeals to Defenders' sense of rightness and fairness – in fact, they honor their tradition-based values just as strongly. However, once the novelty wears off, Defenders may wonder how practical their Diplomat lovers' ideas are.

Settling down and stabilizing are always on Defenders' minds, and they tend to expect their Diplomat partners to become more practical, with whom they can set up their households. Diplomats primarily project their thoughts into the future and worry about what may become of things. This focus may test their Defender partners' patience. Among Defenders, everything practical happens in the present. It's easy for Diplomats to wrestle with concerns about global warming or the effects of nationalism on society while forgetting to buy milk on the way home.

The focus of Observant and Intuitive individuals always differs, and the practical always tests the ideal.

Defenders may think about the future and global concerns as much as Diplomats. They're just unlikely to judge Diplomats' worries as immediate to their lives. Defenders understand what they can handle efficiently and are realistic about their concerns. After a brief appreciation of their Diplomat partners' perspectives, they may reject all their "what ifs" as an inefficient waste of mental time and energy. They might find nothing realistically actionable about Diplomats' interests. In turn, Diplomats might consider their abstract thinking superior to that of their Defender lovers as they become bored with conversations highlighting the brass tacks of their partners' days.

When Emotions Rule

Both Defenders and Diplomats may find themselves making decisions based on emotional rather than rational content. Both types are quite capable of being coolly rational. However, this isn't usually their opening move. Both prefer instead to prioritize how their decisions affect others.

Despite a preference to see the world through the lens of Feeling, sometimes these couples need to deal with hard facts in ways where emotions may even get in the way. While there's likely always some emotional undercurrent in all purposeful activities, for Defender–Diplomat couples, their feelings may take precedence over important details. For example, if they love a house that's filled with wonderful memories and yet discover that downsizing is necessary, they may need to abandon any sentimental notions to do what must be done. There may be times when understanding their shared preference for sentiment over sound practicality leads them to make choices neither is entirely comfortable with.

When these partners' feelings hold a crucial position in their lives, the potential for a constant state of drama exists. It can be positive drama expressed as enthusiasm, negative drama expressed as tragedy, or anything in between. While Defenders' Judging trait may try to compel order, too much emotional material may slip in to allow it. Excess emotionalism can create volatility and unpredictability, much to their

dismay. However, people feel what they feel. These types can't tame emotions in quite the same way logic can tame wayward rationality.

Diplomats are far freer and more expressive with their emotions than Defenders, who lean toward greater inhibition. There may not be a difference in their actual emotional states, but their degrees of openness can be quite distinct. Diplomats' emotive displays may be overwhelming for Defenders who choose stability over volatility. Consequently, rather than risk an onslaught of emotions from their Diplomat lovers, Defenders may opt to remain even more reticent about voicing their feelings and preferences. This can result in a severe imbalance in their relationships.

Rebalancing Defender–Diplomat Relationships

Being Open-Minded

Defenders aren't known for being the most open-minded of types. Similarly, while their Intuition nudges them to open their minds, Diplomats remain protective of – and stay committed to – their ideals. For such couples, it may take special effort to acknowledge the value of each other's points of view.

This goes beyond "we should do this" versus "we should do that." There are unique perspectives involved. Opening their minds may go beyond simply agreeing to fully appreciating what each brings to their relationships. To support the bond between Defender and Diplomat partners, their growth and development as committed lovers may depend on exploring beyond their comfort zones. To do this, here is an exercise these couples can try.

- Sitting together with a notebook and sharing their feelings and opinions in written form can be helpful in promoting understanding.
- This involves these partners each taking a pressing topic and writing anything from a paragraph, poem, or letter describing their thoughts and feelings.
- If one partner is more reticent than the other during a discussion, writing beforehand may help put them on equal footing.

- Defenders have the advantage of being able to think through responses. They can take the time they need without the pressure.
- This may work for any point of contention that arises, and each type making their case on paper beforehand may slow down arguments when opinions differ.

Being Careful with Criticism

In working out their dissimilar perspectives, both Defenders and Diplomats must mete out criticism gingerly. Their reliance on the Feeling trait for assessing situations means each may suffer emotional wounds with little effort or intent by their partners. In loving relationships, partners inevitably hurt each other's feelings on occasion because they care about the opinions of their partners. Defender–Diplomat couples can return from occasional lapses in kindness or judgment, but if they occur with regularity, recovery may be difficult. If criticism is necessary, it's important to provide – and accept – it with respect. Here are some ways these lovers can approach this.

- Defender–Diplomat couples might want to discuss criticism with a focus on feelings and actions, rather than on each other's nature and character.
- Starting a conversation with, "I feel angry when you..." is likely to yield more receptiveness than, "Sometimes, you're a lazy, inconsiderate slob." Not only is it difficult to start an argument around someone's stated feelings, but it also helps avoid an accusing or attacking tone which is likely to raise these partners' defenses.
- Say or write, "I feel..." followed by the relevant feeling.
- Then add, "when you..." followed by the act that evokes the feeling. "I feel lonely when you spend all your time at home reading." "I feel frustrated when you don't take the trash out after you've promised to."
- It's a very good idea to balance this occasionally with some positive, "I feel..." statements – "I feel so happy when we go for a walk together."

Deal with the Facts

It's unlikely Defender–Diplomat couples would ever dispense with emotional considerations altogether, nor should they. Good decisions can flow from feelings in the right circumstances. A certain warm rationality can be a product of emotions – deciding to treat coworkers with more respect, for example.

These lovers may want to guard against over-romanticization or other excessive emotional responses and learn to recognize when emotions are best brushed aside, at least partially and temporarily. Both types can stretch beyond their emotional comfort zones when necessary, but it might take some special effort for such couples to spot their "default" emotional inclinations. For Defender–Diplomat couples, it's less about squelching emotions than it is finding balance with a more rational approach.

Defender–Sentinel Relationships

Couples with the same core traits usually understand each other best. Defenders in love with other Sentinels share a sense of responsibility, caring, and practical order. Traditions that reflect their culture, past, and upbringing blanket them. Even if these romantic partners are of different cultures and were raised differently, they're likely to have a lot in common, all the same. While the specifics may differ, each type understands the other's style of building useful foundations and maintaining the traditional values and beliefs that are elemental to their backgrounds. It won't matter if one is from uptown and the other downtown – Defenders and other Sentinels recognize similar fundamentals in one another regardless.

Balanced Defender–Sentinel Relationships

Finding Commitment and Clarity

From the moment there's a sufficient level of commitment, things tend to be quite serious between Defenders and the Sentinels they love. Both feel a strong pull toward stabilizing their lives with hearth and home, as well as their apparent desire to settle down with someone with whom they can build a life. When they feel sure of the other being the "one," plans are made, and directions are charted in clear terms.

Sharing a Down-to-Earth Approach

Defenders love other Sentinels for their down-to-Earth approach and the effort they put into life. Diligence is very attractive to Sentinels. Together, they embrace the traditional wisdom and understanding of those who have gone before them, rather than theoretical mores. This isn't to say their romances are devoid of imagination. It's just Defenders and other Sentinels prefer the imaginative manipulation of concrete matters and the creative interpretation of time-honored methods. They're likely to follow culturally-approved codes than try something experimental. Diligent attention to tasks today assures them that their lives together can work out tomorrow. Unlike their Intuitive friends who simply dream of a better future, these types lay down reliable, real-time foundations for it.

Protecting Those They Love

It's no accident this group received the label of "Sentinel." They protect the things already in their lives – and in the lives of those they love. Defenders and other Sentinels stand guard and do whatever they can to meet the needs and reasonable desires of their significant others. When two Sentinel types merge, a deep, mutual caretaking develops that's unsurpassed by pairings with other personality types. Defenders may discover heartfelt loyalty with other types. However, they never attain the level of practicality as when they join with other Sentinels.

Unbalanced Defender–Sentinel Relationships

Too Much of a Good Thing

When individuals with similar traits fall in love, the combination can

result in too much of a good thing. People often pass through stages where they yearn for change – even tradition-bound Defenders and other Sentinels. Wondering if a new, exciting upgrade might add some zing, Defenders and Sentinels who fall victim to "sameness" may criticize the very routine they once treated as a perk. The old bumper sticker that asked, "Are we having fun yet?" might become a nagging question in these couples' minds.

There's a difference between satisfaction and joy. Defender–Sentinel couples who don't infuse a little novelty and excitement into their relationships may find that satisfaction alone eventually becomes too little for them. However, note the word "may," as this statement is a cautionary warning rather than a prediction. Even among similar types, with all they have in common, different people need various levels of stimulation and excitement and may question their happiness as they go through life's stages. Sometimes their uncertainty is in passing, and sometimes it shakes their worlds. For Defender–Sentinel couples, stability becoming stagnation can be a troubling issue.

Missed Opportunities

It's not only about boredom. Such couples may become so insulated inside their routines that they miss out on other available opportunities. If they focus on "what is" and reinforce one another's reliance on the status quo, any other growth is limited to the small space they happily create together. An insular life is a reasonable choice for any couple. However, for a choice to be a choice, they must also consider other alternatives. Defenders with Sentinel partners, safe within their bubbles, may never discover their options, much less reach out to them.

Personal growth almost always entails a measure of risk, and relationships that promote growth allow partners to take chances. Professionally, avoiding the risk of moving to more lucrative or satisfying jobs can mean lost opportunities. Perhaps spending the time or money to pursue more training or education seems frivolous in a household that values sureness. After all, more learning doesn't necessarily guarantee more success. Trying different paths may feel like gambling when perfectly good employment already exists.

"Playing it safe" socially limits some types of growth. Trying new things with new people not only adds excitement, but it fosters a more sophisticated understanding of the greater world. A predictable life, by definition, is one without a lot of variety, and variety can keep people more engaged in life.

When Both Are Certain, Who Decides?

Order and predictability are essential to lovers in Defender–Sentinel relationships, and the Judging trait inevitably contains a degree of certainty. But "order" for some may mean a ranch house in the heart of the suburbs, designed for raising four kids. Others may envision a city townhouse near work and parenting an only child. When the Judging trait overheats, partners are convinced their positions stand alone as the best – a recipe for tension in romantic relationships. Once they've decided something, they simply want to move on to the next step. With Defender–Sentinel couples, stubborn determination can consume the harmony in their households like a flame consumes oxygen.

Rebalancing Defender–Sentinel Relationships

Deciding to Add a Little Spice

Like the Introvert who shakes a lot of hands to keep a job, Sentinels and their Defender sweethearts can consider shaking up their routines occasionally – even at the price of a little discomfort. This doesn't mean they should destroy the stable worlds they create. But wandering outside their routines, spontaneously exploring the exotic, could add a smidgeon of jalapeño to their mild gazpacho of daily living. The food metaphor can be taken literally. One surprising the other by serving a romantic dinner filled with adventurous foods – on an average Wednesday, no less – guarantees some excitement on an otherwise predictable weeknight.

All couples must decide their tolerance for spice. Some prefer a lot of jalapeños, others only a little, and still others abstain. Lovers must determine what makes their individual lives more interesting and provides them with fond memories. Those in Defender–Sentinel couples can periodically ask themselves, "When was the last time I surprised the person I love?"

Explore the World

In this swiftly changing world, yesterday's opportunities are already meaningless, and tomorrow's will fly quickly by. Defender–Sentinel couples who remain cloistered may miss them all. Being protective of the lifestyles they value is admirable, and many couples would be envious of the closeness that entails. Nonetheless, a lot of opportunities in the 21st century focus less on preserving the status quo than exploring new horizons. Here are some examples of ways these lovers can discover that growth happens just outside their comfort zone.

- Online courses taken together provide an opportunity for Defender–Sentinel couples to expand their horizons and grow closer from the comfort of their cherished home environments.
- Attending conferences or public trade shows can be a wonderful way to find out what is taking place beyond their doors.

Compromise Is Usually the Key

The Judging trait, with all its certitude, doesn't have to serve as a lock on opinions – it can also act as a tool for sorting options in an orderly fashion. Compromise loosens individual preferences and opinions enough to allow other's to be considered, and it's crucial to successful relationships. Compromise affirms both partners in couples because it takes both positions seriously. Here's a technique these twosomes can try.

- Creating a two-column chart can be a useful technique for creating compromise. Listing what each partner wants or needs, and then finding commonalities, organizes the issues and creates a foundation for finding compromise.
- Caution: It's important to remember that everyone gives a little and receives a little in a compromise. Each win because both walk away with some concessions, but both also surrender something as well. Defenders may need to take care that they don't surrender too much.

Defender–Explorer Relationships

Defender–Explorer couples tend to be the oddest of all combinations. As Observant types, both live "in the moment," but in drastically different ways. "The moment," for Defenders, brings a chance to manage matters at hand responsibly. They consider consequences, but they link them strongly to their present activities. They believe that what they do now carries the future. Explorers, however, regard "the moment" as an opportunity to discover new, enjoyable experiences. Their satisfaction is immediate, and future costs aren't as important to them. This lack of concern allows Explorers to bend the rules when they believe it's worthwhile. Of course, as previously discussed, Defenders are the guardians of such rules, but opposites do indeed sometimes attract.

Balanced Defender–Explorer Relationships

Sometimes Opposites Do Attract

Being vastly different can be ideal for generating some wonderful relationships. Defenders and Explorers sometimes get together because staid, organized Defenders find they need some excitement, relaxation, and spontaneity in their lives. If they seek a little enjoyment, Explorers often bring it. Explorers likely experience the practical difficulties that living so exclusively in the moment produce. They may search for ways to introduce organizing and planning into their lives and may discover completion with the right Defender love interests. If both types understand their differences, don't force their perspectives, and have a degree of tolerance, they may come across each other at the right time and create outstanding bonds.

Love Meets Needs

Lest this sounds too utilitarian, consider the many factors that go into forming romantic relationships. As a broad example, younger Explorers often experience challenging times when their unique personalities may not fit in. This alienation potentially affects their sense of belonging for the rest of their lives. Defenders create a welcoming space that fulfills that basic need. Their nurturing natures blanket those they love with the warmth of belonging.

Explorers, on the other hand, broaden Defenders' worlds. If they can gently tug Defenders out of their isolated, guarded existence, Explorers can add variety, excitement, and a greater understanding of otherwise unfamiliar things to their lives. Defenders may not always admit they need this, but some part of them typically seeks the kind of joy Explorers can supply.

Unbalanced Defender–Explorer Relationships

Roles That Grow Old

Defenders and Explorers may discover that their roles, being so distinct, become strictly defined. Defenders take on the "adult" role of organizing and meeting obligations, and the Explorers become the more creative, fun-loving partners. These accepted roles may work well for a lifetime, or they may become tiresome quickly. If these couples aren't careful, their relationships might start to resemble those of parents and children. It becomes burdensome for Defenders who take all the responsibility while Explorers enjoy a carefree, almost childlike, existence. Defenders may insist that the weekend is right for spring cleaning, while Explorers would rather attend a local art fair. This imbalance can become problematic, and potentially, the "adults" can grow weary, while the "children" start to feel inferior.

When Stability Meets Spontaneity

Defenders easily become set in their ways, while Explorers may change their opinions or interests within minutes. The things that excite Explorers today, they'll ignore tomorrow. Defenders depend on each day looking like the one that came before it. Explorers may

see their Defender partners' routines as a non-stop hindrance to their free expression, and have lots of difficulty in relationships they believe confine them.

Commitment, by its nature, assures predictability, and predictable situations make Defenders the most comfortable. On the contrary, Explorers are independent, sometimes to the extreme, which often renders them commitment-shy. Defenders' domestic sanctuaries can feel like cozy prisons to Explorers, and they may resist signing on to such a committed lifestyle for the long haul. If one seeks commitment while the other yearns for freedom, the early stages of these relationships can become fraught with difficulty.

Should Explorers decide to exercise their independent streaks, they might go off on their own, hurting their Defender lovers who wonder why they don't include them. Explorers may harmlessly assume that Defenders aren't interested in joining them and believe they're honoring the Defenders' interests. Instead, Defenders may feel as if their Explorer sweethearts don't want them around. Defenders build their social lives around the people in their households, and the idea of their partners excluding them is painful.

Unkind Labeling

Defender–Explorer couples can easily fall into the trap of labeling each other unkindly. Disparaging labels don't even have to be said aloud to cause damage. Even if it's part of their internal self-talk, such assessment of loving partners can erode relationships. Defenders may forget who they fell in love with, and begin using words like "lazy" and "irresponsible" when the dishes remain unwashed. Explorers may discover words like "uptight" and "boring" seeping into their consciousness when their Defender partners insist on completing chores before taking a hike along the river.

It doesn't take a psychologist to guess where such labeling could lead. In time, there may be a gradual loss of respect that permeates their entire relationship. Instead of seeing the qualities that they once loved, Defenders and Explorers may only see the negative labels they now apply.

Rebalancing Defender–Explorer Relationships

Respectful Communication

The key to countering roles that become too rigid or unbalanced may entail viewing the imbalance as a respect issue. Defenders might consider respecting themselves enough to reject carrying the burden of being the sole working member of the household. If they find they're playing the "parent" role too often, it may be time for a talk. Communicating feelings and setting boundaries can re-establish balance. There's nothing wrong with saying, "I feel stressed too much of the time. If you took care of the laundry occasionally, it might lift some of the pressure." As a bonus, Explorers taking on more responsibility could promote a greater sense of self-respect. As they expand their contributions to the household, they might discover a sense of being true equals, and that could positively impact their self-image.

However, Defenders should extend respect toward Explorers as well, and remember that they fell in love with those who may have a higher tolerance for disorder and a lower threshold for repetitive activity. When the dishes need doing, Explorers' attention may be at locations other than the kitchen sink – but they're probably not that different from who they were when the sparks first flew. It's usually destructive to require partners to change their essential characteristics in loving relationships. Nobody should confuse encouraging more responsibility with demanding it. Here are some ways these couples can address this.

- Respectful communication includes airing problems and disappointments while keeping in mind both Defenders and their Explorer lovers hold a legitimate perspective.
- Compromise may be crucial to such communication, and drawing lines that are too firm is probably unproductive. Explorers usually have a flexible mindset. If Defenders borrow just a little of their outlook while relying on their natural ability to organize and deal with practical problems, creative solutions tend to appear.
- Perhaps playing music to energize Explorers and make house cleaning more like a party is the key to getting more help.
- When bad labels seem to crop up in conversations, take a moment and write down five good labels. Instead of "lazy" and "irresponsible,"

find other words like “creative” and “curious” to apply. Instead of “uptight” and “boring,” try “caring” and “reliable.” Negative labels may show up occasionally. That doesn’t mean they must be in charge.

Defender–Explorer romances present Defenders with wonderful opportunities to expand their horizons. Following their Explorer lovers’ leads in reacting spontaneously and learning to unclench their hold on the universe just a bit can be most therapeutic. Everybody needs a break, including Defenders. All they need is the willingness to permit themselves to try something new. Releasing themselves from the routine may be a little frightening for them at first, but they’re likely not to abandon their familiar discipline permanently. It’s an excursion into their Explorer lovers’ worlds, not a permanent transfer.

Conclusion

While only a couple of other Sentinel types cherish home and hearth as much as protective Defenders, this doesn’t mean domesticity lacks attraction for all other types. Everybody needs to belong, and “home” – as a place or as an idea – can be one of the most powerful ways of meeting that need. With the right chemistry up front, and patience and tolerance later, there’s no such thing as a personality type that isn’t a match for loyal, loving Defenders.

Friendships

Warm, Cautious Connections

Given how warm and generous Defenders are, it's not surprising that others enjoy their company. However, earning their real friendship isn't quick or easy. People with this personality type are often shy and a little protective of themselves, and they need to be able to connect through shared values. Most of Defenders' friends are made not during random encounters, but through comfortable, consistent contact, such as in a class or in the workplace where they have the time to get to know each other little by little.

A lot of what makes Defenders' friendships grow is the mutual support, advice, and reassurance that these companions give each other. These types crave positive feedback, and admitting this need shows their vulnerability. If this openness is handled with care, it creates the deep bonds that Defenders look for. If not, friendship is unlikely to prosper.

Giving Too Much, Asking Too Little

As their friendships develop, Defenders strive to meet their friends' needs, sometimes to the point of neglecting their own. For example, they may go clearly out of their way to stick to even minor commitments, or try not to disagree for fear of causing conflict. Cynical people might call this naïve, and may even take advantage of it, but Defenders eventually push such people out of their lives.

True chums are touched by Defenders' over-reaching generosity and try to return it whenever possible. However, these types are often so

tolerant and humble that they fail to make their own needs known, leaving even very caring friends a little out of the loop. Lopsided contributions to friendship, emotional or otherwise, may become habitual despite the best of intentions – it's difficult for other types to match the selfless, caring hearts of Defenders.

Strong as Stone

While they're known for being considerate, Defenders also have a resolute core that gives them great fortitude. They may sometimes bend to the desires of others instead of declaring their own, but they never lose sight of what they want. They often use their inner strength to lift those they're close to and are always ready with open ears and kind words. Patient, practical, and principled, Defenders make for precious pals.

These types draw much of their strength from the human connections in their lives. They sincerely appreciate their friends' support, and caring for others affirms their sense of self. Defenders crave a world where people are responsible, trustworthy, and kind. Having friendships where these values are practiced makes them happy.

Commonality and Community

Defenders' desire for stability is reflected in their choice of companions, as they like being around those who share their values and culture. Friendships are likely to flourish in environments that affirm the things they've adopted through their own experiences. Of course, what's compatible depends on individual Defenders' personal histories. Anything from a traditional church to an established political group could make it possible for them to find friendship through shared beliefs.

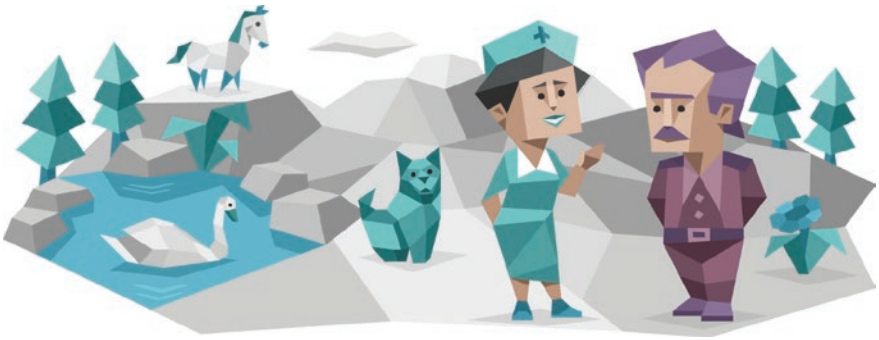
Defenders aren't known for their cultural mobility, however, and they find comfort in the familiar. These types may enjoy socializing in whatever community feels like home, but rarely feel pulled to explore other ways of life. People who don't share their views and standards are unlikely to appeal as friends to Defenders, who may even be disturbed by stark diversity. Highly non-confrontational, these types show their disapproval by avoidance, and this can limit their social growth.

Pleasant Surprises

Of course, this isn't to say that Defenders can't build friendships with different types of people – they just need a reason. If there's one thing these types appreciate, it's finding others who feel as strongly as they do about the value of honest friendship. Nearly any commendable personality facet, such as trustworthiness, can make someone appealing to Defenders.

Defenders and Friends of Other Types

Defenders can enjoy friendship with almost anyone who meets such essential standards. We'll look at some of the virtues that these types can share with each Role group through friendship, as well as some areas of potential difficulty. Most importantly, we'll also go over some helpful things Defenders can do to make friendships work with other personality types.



Defender–Analyst Friendships

Defender–Analyst friendships don't usually benefit from quick, natural alignment, but the potential is certainly there. The dynamic natures of Commanders and Debaters can be understandably off-putting to Defenders, and there's nothing wrong with this. If anything, Defenders can teach Extraverted Analysts a lot about patience and compassion if they're willing to learn. When Defenders befriend these types, they, in turn, gain gutsy, creative allies to help them through life's toughest challenges.

Balanced Defender–Analyst Friendships

Support and Assistance

Not all Analyst friends demand such thick skin, though. Defenders can be quite drawn to the quieter, thoughtful natures of Logicians and Architects. It may not always be easy to follow Logicians' curious musings, but Defenders respect their desire for knowledge. Likewise, Architects' purposeful – if sometimes clinical – approach appeals to their sense of order and organization. Defenders offer Analyst friends practical, graceful examples of the value of human understanding, and some gentle counterpoints to their sharper edges. In turn, Defenders can access Analysts' ingenuity to help their daily lives.

Incisive Perspectives

On the lighter side, Defenders appreciate Analyst friends' witty humor, though it may sometimes go too far. Analysts love to take things apart mentally, and their observations on life's frustrations can align nicely with Defenders' discriminating sensibilities. These friends usually have no trouble finding some complaints to share about the world around them.

While this might seem negative, it can, in fact, be very comforting and affirming for Defenders to find kindred souls who share similar frustrations. Both Defenders and Analysts tend to have strong views and a thirst for sensibility. Being able to laugh off stressful grievances brings these friends closer, and their bond ultimately helps them to make positive changes together.

Unbalanced Defender–Analyst Friendships

Disheartening Disconnection

There are challenges, of course – Defenders often find Analysts to be unrealistic, emotionally unavailable, or overly harsh. They may not be able to muster much enthusiasm for Analysts' grand ideas and esoteric plans, and may, in turn, be disappointed by Analysts' indifference to their more grounded interests. These two types may struggle to agree on mutually fulfilling ways to spend their time and energy together.

Defenders are also quite often disappointed by Analysts' neglectful attitude toward maintaining friendships. Analysts think nothing of long silences or absences between good chums, but this seems downright bizarre to Defenders, who all but define the quality of social relationships by their consistency and attentiveness. It takes time and effort for them to develop a good rapport, and if Analysts aren't present often enough, Defenders won't find their friendship worthwhile.

One-Sided Communication

Another likely problem in Defender–Analyst friendships is imbalanced communication. Analysts love to talk about their opinions and may dominate conversations and decisions within their friendships. Defenders aren't likely to take on the ordeal of arguing with even trusted Analyst friends, and Analysts may mistake their quiet tolerance for agreement.

This tends to make expressing anything from heartfelt views on life to preferences on where to eat lunch frustrating for Defenders. They can quickly become overshadowed by Analysts' notable lack of consideration. Defenders' equally remarkable grace and patience only go so far, and they might get fed up if they can't find a way to make their own needs known.

Rebalancing Defender–Analyst Friendships

Connecting Through Each Other's Virtues

Defenders and Analysts can build connection despite their differences by appreciating the benefits of shared companionship. Defenders tend to foster subtle but critical strengths that Analysts often lack: humility, kindness, and practicality. They can offer to smooth out the social friction that Analysts often experience due to their intellectual bluster and emotional ineptitude, helping them to be happier and more successful with people.

In return, Defenders like how intelligent Analyst friends can enhance their lives. Analysts love beating life's challenges, and gladly step in to aid Defenders who are intimidated by the world's often unkind assaults. Defenders can call on Analyst friends' creativity – they love

being asked about their opinions and methods. Frequently requesting and offering advice back and forth is a great way for these friends to get past differences and gain each other's strengths.

Firm Honesty

It's difficult to open up to Analysts, who can be insensitive, but it's a perfect chance for Defenders to build self-confidence by expressing their needs. Here are some hints Defenders can keep in mind.

- If they calmly explain to Analysts how their behavior and decisions affect their friendship, they'll get results. It can be as simple as saying, "We usually go to your favorite pizza place, but pizza all the time makes me not want to go out. I'd really like Thai food tonight."
- There's no rational argument against mutual respect and care in friendship, and while Analysts understand this, they often need firm direction in such matters.
- Getting past Analysts' emotional blindness goes both ways, and Defenders may have to work at drawing out their friends' deeper needs, thoughts, and feelings.
- Analysts are unlikely to be in tune with their own emotions or discuss them without prompting. Putting such questions bluntly and logically may be best, as this is Analysts' communication style.
- Simply asking Analysts what they prefer, are willing to do, and how they feel can get Defenders the information they need to take good care of their Analyst friends.

Functioning, fair friendships with Analysts are certainly rewarding. Defenders can offer Analysts a friendly ear for their intellectual ranting, and help soothe their frustration with a dysfunctional world. Caring for others is often quite a rewarding feeling for Defenders, and Analysts in particular need understanding, tolerant friends.

In turn, Defenders find clever, thoughtful support from their Analyst friends, whose vigorous minds are always at the ready. Having motivated Analysts as friends can feel like divine intervention when life's problems threaten, and Defenders shouldn't hesitate to befriend these types.

Defender–Diplomat Friendships

Defender–Diplomat friendships can be some of the most enjoyable among personality types. Both types value cooperation, social harmony, and tend to share a genuine desire to be supportive. Not only that, but ideals that Diplomats hold dear – fairness, kindness, and generosity – resonate pleasantly with Defenders' sentimental values. Advocates and Mediators are especially natural fits for Defenders, as their shared Introversion makes them easy to spend time with. The way that Protagonists and Campaigners mix energy with idealism holds appeal to Defenders as well – who, in turn, offer these types a cautious perspective to balance their headstrong enthusiasm.

Balanced Defender–Diplomat Friendships

Harmonious Ideals

One of the most rewarding results of Defender–Diplomat friendship is when they cooperate to bring their values into reality. Diplomats never tire of sharing their ideas for how the world could be better, and who better than Defenders to find practical ways to make such ideas come to fruition.

While Defenders may sometimes find Diplomats (especially Prospecting types) a little too whimsical, they nonetheless appreciate the beauty of their fanciful notions. The way these things seem to bubble up from nowhere intrigues Defenders, as their own thoughts tend to be based on careful consideration. When these pals decide on action together, their unique but complementary natures make everyone's lives better.

Joy and Discovery

Defenders may not be very adventurous as a rule, but Diplomats' considerate, empathetic companionship may be the perfect outlet for them to explore and try new things. Diplomat friends are unlikely to push Defenders out of their comfort zones too quickly, as they tend to be very attentive to their feelings. In this supportive atmosphere, Defenders can drop their defenses, take a few risks and grow, knowing they have these caring friends at their side.

The flip side is how sensible and wise Defenders can be – they help keep wilder Diplomat friends out of trouble (or, at least, warned and kindly consoled). Diplomats appreciate the way Defenders create a smooth path through life, avoiding conflict and getting things done. Their focused dedication may seem like magic to Diplomats who feel lost in the chaos. When these comrades each put their best feet forward, they can balance idealism and practicality to bring strength and joy to one another's lives.

Unbalanced Defender–Diplomat Friendships

Different Realities

Unfortunately, even shared values of peace and harmony can clash if they're expressed through various cultures or belief systems. Defenders often look to the past for tried and true examples of what works best, while Diplomats happily embrace revolutionary change. A classic example is that of traditionally religious Defenders clashing with progressive, atheist Diplomats – they might feel as though they're living in different worlds.

A more general example is how Diplomats often embrace wild ideas and chase unrealistic but beautiful dreams. Defender friends might find this behavior tiring, preferring more realistic efforts to achieve the possible in the here and now. These types like a stable foundation in life, and can be concerned by how fast Diplomats – especially Campaigners and Mediators – embrace change. Frustration may result if these chums can't reconcile their very different approaches to universal ideals.

Chancy Business

Watching friends fall into things that seem imprudent or even perilous isn't easy for Defenders. Whether it's dubious romantic interests, implausible beliefs, or precarious financial habits, Diplomats' passionate embracing of life can alarm Defenders. They often feel powerless to avert their pals' questionable decisions, and are afraid to offend them by expressing their disagreement.

These types may also run into trouble if they share contrary advice with their Diplomat friends. To Diplomats, this can feel like someone stepping all over their dreams, no matter how kindly it's delivered. Defenders may be aghast that something seemingly flawed holds appeal for Diplomats, and likewise, Diplomats may be frustrated by their Defender friends' rejection of fantastical possibilities. Defenders can only handle so much stress, and at some point, these companions may drift apart.

Rebalancing Defender–Diplomat Friendships

Gentle Respect

Friendships between Defenders and Diplomats are among the few where the Observant and Intuitive traits can easily come into harmony. Defenders may be sensitive, but Diplomats' deep empathy – and the fact that Defenders gladly reciprocate – go a long way toward building lasting relationships. There's little doubt that Defenders and Diplomat friends can care for each other, but it requires each type to share their needs honestly. Here are some things Defenders can keep in mind.

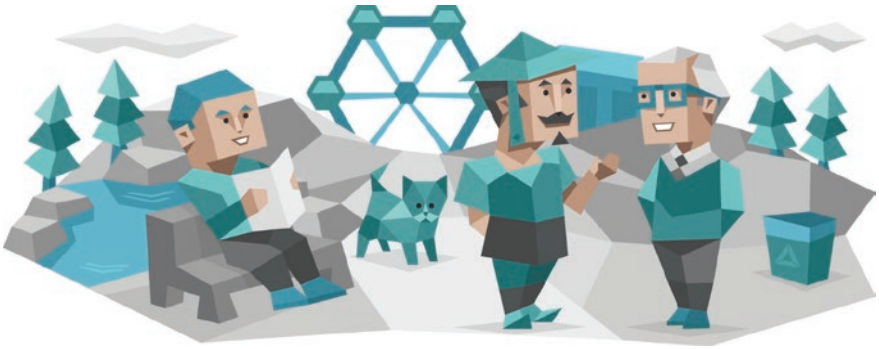
- Unlike rebalancing communication with Analysts (which relies on highlighting the adverse effects of behavior), Defenders and their Diplomat friends can explain how each other's behavior makes them feel.
- All that's needed is a gentle tone and heartfelt honesty, as these personality types are both caring listeners.
- When these allies realize that their words or actions are hurting each other, their differing approaches can be put aside in favor of the common emotional ideals they share. Open communication makes this far easier.

Stepping In

Respectful support is appreciated, but Defenders can also recognize when it's time to actively offer their advice and help to their Diplomat friends. Some steps they can take include the following.

- Diplomats are dreamers, but there are moments when a more grounded perspective is vital, even if it isn't requested.
- Intervention isn't easy for Defenders to initiate, but they may regret withholding their much-needed guidance for the sake of emotional consideration.
- If their advice is ignored, Defenders can make it clear that they support their Diplomat friends while holding true to their perspective. They may have to accept an ongoing stream of fanciful ideas and choices from Diplomats – it's who they are.
- If Diplomats move in disturbing directions, Defenders can take solace in knowing that they tried to help, and refuse to be drawn in. Avoiding participation in things they truly dislike is an important part of Defenders' personal development, and helps them maintain fair and respectful friendships with Diplomats.

Defender–Sentinel Friendships



Other Sentinels are a good fit for Defenders, who share their appreciation for dependability and practicality. These friendships center around day-to-day activities and life in general, rather than ambition or curiosity. Having someone steadfast and sensible in their lives is no small consideration for both these types.

Balanced Defender–Sentinel Friendships

Reassuring Steadiness

Sentinels' social leanings may appeal to Defenders as well, whether such friends are Introverts or Extraverts. Either way, their discussions are likely to revolve around work, life, and recent events. Sentinels aren't big on esoteric topics, grand plans, and theoretical analyses. In fact, Defenders often consider it an opportunity missed when broad, impersonal topics dominate a discussion instead of using that time to catch up with each other. Among Sentinel friends, Defenders can find comfortable connection rather than intellectual grandstanding or ideological debate.

When emotionally charged situations and major life events do occur, Defenders appreciate how Sentinel friends stand by their side through thick and thin. They may not be comfortable with public attention, but they enjoy knowing Sentinel friends are always there with rock-solid support.

Stability in Action

Favoring stable foundations doesn't mean that Defender–Sentinel friends don't care about progress. However, where Intuitive or Prospecting types see the future as a road with many distracting branches, Defenders want to be trains on a track with everything moving in a controlled direction. Having Sentinel friends who share the same organized way of living is like having additional engines to help drive their train forward. These friends can reinforce each other's progress in life.

When Defenders need help restoring order to their lives, the judicious, practical touch of Sentinel friends is perfect, and they, in turn, appreciate Defenders' prudence. Whether requiring discerning solutions or needing soothing reassurance, these pals are likely to become cores of support for each other. Together, they create a safe, reliable place from which to act with confidence, helping both these types stay on track.

Relatable Differences

Personality traits that Defenders find challenging in some types may be a little easier to handle in Sentinels. For example, Consuls' sociable,

kind way of expressing Extraversion is likely to appeal to Defenders and can inspire them to engage with people. When it comes to the Thinking trait, Logisticians' practical rationality is easier for Defenders to appreciate than the sophisticated theorizing of Analysts. Even the steely nature of Executives makes some sense to Defenders, as they see how effective it is at getting things done.

Sentinel friends offer Defenders doorways to personal balance, challenging some of their limits while staying soberly grounded alongside them in the present. Shared values focusing on stability, pragmatism, and dedication make friendships within this Role a good way for Defenders to learn and grow, as well as find rewarding bonds. Commonality helps these chums see eye to eye while they learn from each other's differing approaches to life.

Unbalanced Defender–Sentinel Friendships

Social Binds

Defenders' unwavering support may put them in a tight spot if friends have a falling-out, and Sentinels aren't immune to social problems. In fact, because they value structure so much, Sentinels often care about status in social hierarchies. Defenders feel a need to create peace among their companions and define their self-esteem in large part by their loyalty. Being pulled in different directions by people they care about can be agonizing for these sensitive types.

There's hardly a good way out of these situations once they've begun. Defenders rarely let themselves abandon feuding friends, but may withdraw emotionally to protect themselves. This doesn't mean that they stop being supportive, but they might not express themselves honestly, trying to stay neutral rather than pick a side. Repressed Defenders aren't happy Defenders, and being caught in the middle wears them down.

Creeping Dullness

Defenders and Sentinel friends are likely to take up a safe, predictable routine together. Their shared unwillingness to try new things or expand boundaries can hold back their development on many fronts.

Not only might these friends miss out on a lot of fun, but they may also allow each other to become comfortable with the mediocre instead of striving for the greatness within them.

While sharing repetitive stability provides a sense of comfort, Defender–Sentinel friends may find the world passing them by. If it were merely the social world, this might seem acceptable, but opportunities for personal growth, gain, and advancement may also be missed. These comrades may do each other a disservice if they don't step out of their comfort zones together now and then to see what life has to offer, and what they're truly capable of.

Rebalancing Defender–Sentinel Friendships

Stealthy Peacemakers

While Defenders may not feel comfortable taking a stand between friends who are at odds, they need not feel powerless in such situations. These types can fairly support both sides by acting as objective observers, and perhaps even secret negotiators. Their strong ethics and great empathy make them well-suited to see where both sides are coming from. They can keep these thoughts in mind as they do so.

- Defenders can avoid playing referee and instead use their caring perspective to privately advise their friends on setting things right.
- Sharing their heartfelt concern for both parties may provide a noble example that motivates others.
- Defenders don't need to push their friends down the right path, but they can make it look very appealing.
- Learning to be bold enough to exercise their wisdom in this way can heal Defenders' social anguish when conflicts arise.

Sensible Change

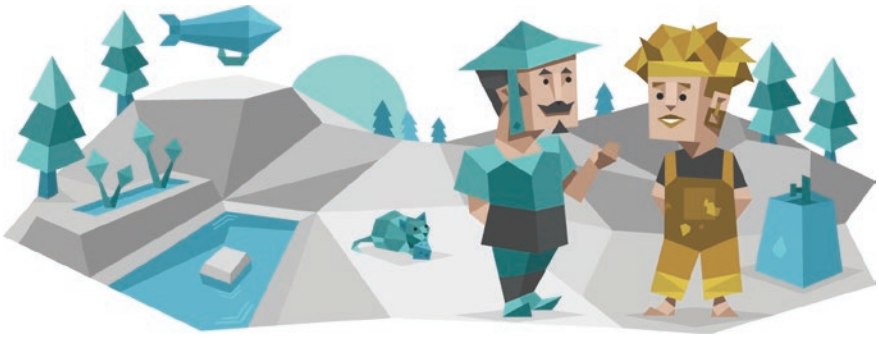
Defenders and their Sentinel friends can keep the following in mind when keeping an eye not just on each other's comfort and happiness, but on what truly benefits each other in the long-term.

- Both types can advise each other when harmful stagnation occurs, and offer support and companionship when change is needed.

- When this means embracing a challenge or a new thing, these friends can open each other's minds as well as hold each other's hands.

This applies to recreational pursuits as much as the rest of life. There's no need to leap off a cliff or take significant risks, but sampling new types of fun with trustworthy Sentinel friends may lead to happy discoveries that Defenders wouldn't find on their own. Engaging in the unknown, at least occasionally, is a wise way for these friends to explore their potential while sharing good times together.

Defender–Explorer Friendships



Explorers' friendship offers Defenders some intimidating opportunities. Explorers live for the pleasures of the moment rather than stability, and this can seem reckless to Defenders. However, these friendships help Defenders understand that not all worthy people are as reserved as they are. Explorers' ability to lose themselves in the moment can be a refreshing counterpoint to Defenders' reluctance.

Balanced Defender–Explorer Friendships

Zest for Life

These types benefit from being led into childlike curiosity by Explorer friends. Letting go and simply moving along with experiences – instead of always planning them – may do them good. It may be alarming at first, but in mild recreational matters where little is at stake, Defenders can practice relinquishing control. Learning to go with the flow is a useful model for these types to master, though perhaps not adopt.

Offering Guidance

Defenders can appreciate how Explorers' passion leads to exciting discoveries, but such carefree enthusiasm may also have unintended consequences. This is where Defenders really shine in such friendships. When they earn Explorers' trust, they can become respected voices of caution. While not expecting Explorers to share their sense of moderation, Defenders can offer a steadying hand with just the right amount of reservation to prevent calamity.

Defenders who come to trust Explorer friends can accept a hand to pull them out of their limited, protective shells into some well-deserved gratification. They can also look to Explorers not only for inspiration but for practical help when they want to follow their own needs and ideas.

Surprising Capability

Defenders might expect that Explorers' more spontaneous style, which is so different from their methodical, dedicated approach, hampers accomplishments. However, while Explorers may change their minds frequently, they do tend to throw themselves into interests that are truly important to them with great success.

When these interests align with Defenders' own, they find Explorer pals to be excellent companions in many ways. For example, as fellow Introverts, Adventurers' tender hearts and quiet curiosity can show Defenders new territory without too much stress. Defenders also appreciate the practical, hands-on side of their Explorer friends. For example, the intense way Virtuosos pursue their ideas is impressive even to such an organized type as Defenders.

Motivation and Elasticity

Defenders can benefit from the undaunted spirit of Explorers as well. While the Extraverted energy of Entrepreneur and Entertainer friends can be a lot to handle, Defenders can follow the trails they blaze. What Explorers lack in steadiness, they make up for with zeal, a boon to Defenders needing help to get moving toward their goals. More than that, Explorers approach experiences and challenges with a flexibility that Defenders can learn from.

In turn, Defenders' abilities may surprise Explorer chums, especially when aimed at a common goal. Explorers grab for what they want, and as masters of sensible planning, Defenders are likely to help them get it with minimal effort. Defenders are demure, and their careful thoughtfulness beautifully balances Explorers' lively adaptability. When these friends share a motivation, each is impressed by what the other can do.

Unbalanced Defender–Explorer Friendships

Dangerous Games

Defenders are likely to be skeptical of, or even disturbed by, their Explorer companions' life choices. Explorers' uninhibited lifestyle and impetuous decisions often go beyond Defenders' boundaries of acceptance. It's not in Defenders' nature to abandon or oppose friends they disagree with, so they may instead get swept up in stressful drama.

Even if Explorers understand Defenders' doubts and fears, they may ignore them, either pushing Defenders into things or deserting them for the duration. The steadfastness that Defenders hold in such high regard can vanish into thin air as Explorers act on their compulsions. The effects of freedom-loving Explorers simply following their hearts can feel devastating to concerned Defender friends.

Expectation and Disappointment

Another area where the fickle interests of Explorer friends can be troubling for Defenders is planning. Defenders thrive on predictability and organization, and quite simply, Explorers don't. While it might be tolerable in small doses, Explorers frequently being late for, altering, or even breaking social engagements is likely to be deeply frustrating to Defenders.

Defenders' desire for thoughtful, emotional treatment may also be disappointed by Explorer friends, despite their best intentions. Explorers are usually quite earnest, but while their care is sincere, it may not be consistent, as they're easily pulled in new directions. Defenders may be hurt by Explorers' odd combination of deep engagement and sudden absences.

Rebalancing Defender–Explorer Friendships

Respecting Limits and Needs

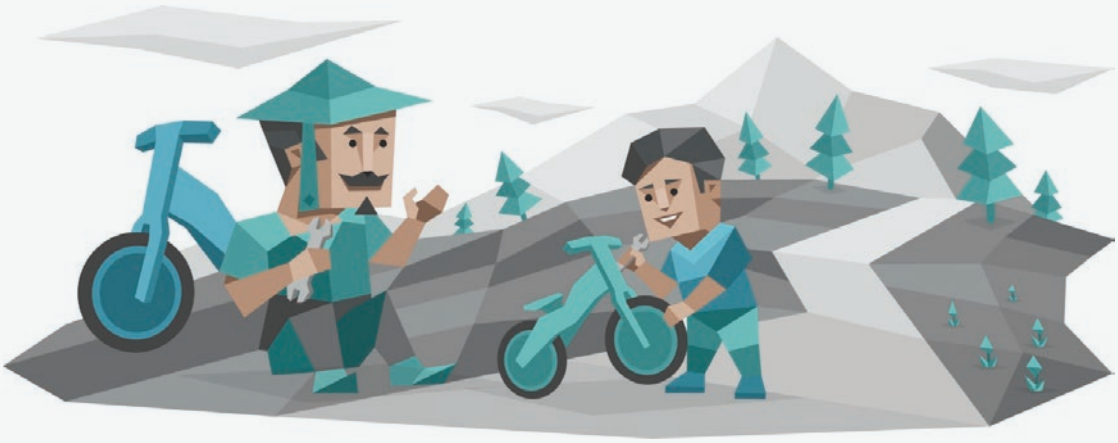
To achieve balance within friendship, Defenders and Explorers need to consciously respect and accept their differences. Here are some ways they can approach this.

- Both must understand when it's time to say "enough" and communicate their needs gently, respectfully, and honestly. Protesting is far harder for Defenders to do than Explorers, but necessary.
- When Defenders reach their limits, Explorer friends can avoid pulling them too far out of their comfort zone. A quiet night in together with takeout and a movie is a good way for these friends to share some fun when Defenders have had enough adventure.
- Likewise, Defenders can stretch themselves when Explorers need company doing something bold and daring, as long as it's not too risky or too often.
- There may also be times when these friends are wise to just give each other some space.
- When Explorers engage in something too extreme for Defenders to support, Defenders can use compassionate detachment – letting their friends be wild and free without them for a while.
- In turn, Explorers can appreciate Defenders' respect, even if it doesn't always come with approval or participation.

These friends may test each other, but in this, there are many opportunities for growth. Friendship itself can be the common focus, with an understanding that sometimes compromises must be made for the sake of worthy friends. This kind of consideration is second nature for Defenders, but they must ask for and receive the same in return for these friendships to work.

Conclusion

Many types tend to be unapologetic about their own needs and interests, and their friends can either join or go their way. This kind of radical individualism feels foreign to Defenders, who prefer intimate bonds of trust and community. Because of this, friendships between Defenders and other personality types require lots of allowances. Defenders need not feel guilty when they choose to step back, and their friends need not feel judged. For Defenders, giving themselves and their friends room to be themselves is a necessary form of care, knowing they can come back together later for something they both enjoy.



Parenthood

Defenders' warmth and care make parenting a task that often comes naturally to them, and many believe it's the work they were born to do. Often perceived as ideal parents, people with the Defender personality type are there for their children, but also know there's more to people than meets the eye, and respect these differences – even if they don't always understand them.

Balanced Defender Parenting

Patience and Caring

From the start, Defenders' altruism is apparent in their parenting approach, as they strive to ensure a safe, stable environment filled with love, care, and support. Their patience comes in handy as their children learn to become more independent and test any limit they can find. While they expect their children to be respectful and well-behaved, these expectations are well-balanced with their understanding of their kids' needs and behaviors, allowing them to truly thrive as individuals.

Reliable and Responsible

Parenting isn't easy for any personality type – not if they're doing it right – but Defenders do have the advantage of not just being caring, but also thoughtful and responsible in how they administer that care. These types take lots of pleasure in the personal responsibility of ensuring that their children grow up healthy, confident, and successful. At the same time, they're humble, and don't take their natural skill for granted.

As very traditional personality types, Defenders are likely to accept traditional roles, with clearly defined parent-child relationships. They see their responsibility (and often rightly so) as being an imparter of their wisdom and values, ensuring that their children understand the importance of dedication and accountability. Defenders are reliable, and view parenting as their ultimate responsibility.

Unbalanced Defender Parenting

Overly Attached

Defenders may be taken by surprise when their children transition – seemingly overnight – from the complete dependence of their infant years to the deep desire for independence that occurs during adolescence. They may struggle when their older, more independent sons and daughters deem their previously appreciated love and support as "overbearing" or "unnecessary." Kids who previously craved their parents' affection and acceptance may no longer seek either. This can be a difficult pill for Defenders to swallow, especially if they take this perfectly normal developmental behavior personally.

Defenders' deep desire to feel needed, especially by their children, can also translate into a tendency to become a bit heavy-handed. While they rarely resort to confrontation to convince their children to heed their advice, they may find themselves attempting to "convince" them to do so using subtler techniques like guilt or even the cold shoulder. This can turn toxic if it occurs too frequently, or if Defenders are unaware they're engaging in these behaviors to get their way.

Perfectionistic Expectations

Although they're generally understanding, Defenders may set unrealistically high expectations for both themselves and their children. They expect to not just meet their kids' needs but excel at doing so by making sure that delicious, healthy food is on the table for every meal, the house is always spotless, and their children are constantly on their best behavior. Anything less than perfect can feel like a failure for Defenders, making them constantly feel like they aren't "succeeding" as parents.

These parents often become uncomfortable when their children don't behave as they should, especially in public. While they're generally understanding about their kids' capabilities, they always promote respectful behavior and truly despise confrontation. Some children may exploit their Defender parents' desire to avoid confrontation and embarrassing social behavior by stretching their boundaries in public. Defenders may, in their desire to appear to be "perfect" parents, allow their sons and daughters to take advantage of their calm, conflict-avoidant personality by letting them ignore their requests and do things they normally wouldn't allow. This can make Defender parents feel taken advantage of and resentful – as if all their hard work and sacrifice isn't appreciated by their children.

Rebalancing Defender Parenting

Learn to Let Go

The desire to feel needed is powerful for Defenders, and it's generally fulfilled throughout their children's early years. Unfortunately, as kids get older, they begin to exercise independence and develop their sense of identity. Consequently, they may reject some of the affection and input they'd accepted from their parents so willingly in the past. These types sacrifice many of their own needs and desires when they become parents. While this is necessary to an extent, it can leave them feeling lost and uncertain about their own identities when their children leave the nest. Defender moms and dads can benefit from learning to let go of the desire to be needed – and embrace the freedom that they gain as their children's independence increases. Here are some steps Defenders can take toward accepting their kids' moving on.

- Modeling the active pursuit of their own personal development is helpful for both Defender parents and their children.
- Engaging in hobbies, participating in spiritual practices, and taking classes to learn something new (or to further existing skills) are just a few of the things that Defenders can do to model personal growth and identity development.
- These pursuits not only provide personal satisfaction, but they also demonstrate different ways to develop greater personal

understanding to children who are attempting to find their own identities.

Re-Evaluate Expectations

As parents, Defenders may believe that they should be able to do it all – to be perfect parents/spouses/employees/etc. – while neglecting to take care of themselves and refusing to ask for help from others. Under this kind of self-imposed stress, these types may become personally offended when their children misbehave, appear ungrateful, or reject their affection or assistance.

In these cases, their expectations as parents aren't always in line with what's realistic or even appropriate. Self-care is necessary for Defenders to function in ways where they're meeting both their own needs and their kids' needs effectively. Allowing their children to grow and build separate identities (while still encouraging proper behavior) is a fundamental part of both their own and their kids' development. Each stage of their children's development requires modifications in their expectations. This is discussed in greater detail in the sections below.

Parenting for Each Stage of Development

Each stage of childhood growth presents both unique challenges and exciting milestones. Learning how to navigate these stages may seem daunting, but the opportunities to build healthy attachment and create meaningful memories make it worth the struggle.

Renowned psychologist Erik Erikson proposed a theory of psychosocial development that identified eight stages, five of which take place between birth and 18 years of age. In this section, we discuss how the strengths and weaknesses of the Defender personality type may affect their parenting at each of the first five stages of psychosocial development.

Building Bonds (Birth–1½ Years)

According to Erikson, the stages of infancy and early childhood last from birth until approximately three years of age. Children in these stages are very dependent on their parents to meet their needs. This is also when the bonds of attachment are created by meeting early childhood needs, developing trusting relationships, and promoting autonomy.

The priority for infants in their journey to attachment is having their basic needs met. From being fed to receiving affection, infants learn to either trust that their parents can provide for them, or they suffer from a sense of mistrust in all their subsequent relationships. If parents are inconsistent in providing for their children, or are particularly violent or neglectful, they'll have difficulty creating positive, trusting attachments with their infants. Attentive, affectionate parents – especially those who engage in consistent physical contact such as snuggling or transporting their children in baby carriers on their body – develop trusting, hopeful relationships with their infants and are likely to have minimal difficulty building comfortable attachments.

Balanced Infant Parenting

Building Bonds

Defenders excel at providing structure for their children and are certainly able to meet their infants' needs. Reliability is crucial in building relationships with infants, and Defender parents are likely to be very attentive to their babies by reliably feeding, changing, and comforting them when necessary. Most Defenders truly savor the infant stage where their children rely on them entirely, and won't hesitate to provide for them consistently and lovingly.

Defender parents thrive on feeling needed, which can provide them with much-needed motivation during the extraordinarily draining infant stage. Where some parents may struggle with maintaining energy during this phase, and suffer from mood swings or other inconsistent behaviors, Defenders' reliability and desire to feel needed allow them to not only survive this stage but even enjoy it. Their constant and consistent attention and affection create the foundation for building trust and instilling hope in their babies – an intrinsic understanding that they're cared for, supported, and can rely on those around them to meet their needs.

Unbalanced Infant Parenting

Lack of Self-Care

Although they're doting, attentive, and responsible parents, Defenders may have difficulty asking for help or taking care of themselves. While it's necessary to devote a large amount of time and energy to caring for young children, these types may become absorbed in their desire to meet all their babies' needs as well as those of other family members, friends, coworkers, or anyone else who seems to need help. This can lead to burnout as well as feelings of resentment or bitterness when they don't receive acknowledgment or gratitude for the services they provide.

The infant and toddler years are some of the most difficult that parents face, as their children are helpless and entirely dependent upon them as caregivers. This combination of high levels of stress and a lack of willingness to seek help from others, especially when combined with a lack of self-care, significantly increases the likelihood that Defenders can suffer from burnout, frustration, resentment, and even depression.

Rebalancing Infant Parenting

Seeking Support and Solace

Balancing their needs with those of their children is one of the most important things that Defender parents can learn. Here are some ways these parents can carve out some all-important "me time":

- Self-care can be something as simple as taking a thirty-minute bath a couple of times a week. Taking one afternoon per week to meet with friends, or scheduling some time alone, can also provide Defender parents time to recharge.
- Even a five-minute "time out" to clear their minds and relax their bodies can help those with young children re-center themselves and increase their patience.
- Writing down their thoughts for a few minutes each day may help Defender parents work through their thoughts. It can also allow them to document both milestones and meaningful moments in their infants' day-to-day lives.

Equally as important as engaging in intentional self-care for Defenders is learning to allow others to help them. There's no shame in asking for help – in fact, the opposite is true! Defenders who admit when they need help and accept offers of help from others will likely find themselves happier, calmer, and more effective in their parenting endeavors. Here are some small steps these parents can take toward accepting the help they need.

- Taking trusted relatives up on babysitting offers and allowing spouses to take over bedtime duties a couple of nights a week not only helps Defender parents, it also provides their infants with the chance to build their relationships with others who love them.
- Paying someone to clean the house or do the yard work once a month can make a big difference in the lives of Defender parents.
- Additionally, learning to say no to the requests of others when they don't have the time or energy can help Defenders find a more beneficial balance between helping others and meeting their own needs.

Testing Boundaries (1½–3 Years)

Once they're mobile, young children become very interested in exploring their environment with their senses. Crawling, walking, grabbing items, putting things in their mouths, and verbal communication are just a few of the ways that toddlers learn about the world around them. During this stage, parents must provide a safe harbor for their children while still allowing them to experience and explore their surroundings. Children who can test boundaries yet still receive parental support and encouragement develop a sense of autonomy. Children who are overly restricted, criticized, or made to feel guilty for their desire to test boundaries ultimately experience a sense of shame, and may suffer from feelings of incompetence or low self-worth.

Balanced Toddler Parenting

Patient and Supportive

Defenders' endless reserves of patience are particularly useful during the difficult toddler years. These parents enjoy promoting their

children's curiosity and independence while still maintaining a safe environment. They take great pleasure in helping their little ones learn how to pick out their own clothes and dress themselves, and how to use and manipulate toys and tools such as forks and spoons. Defenders tend to find great joy in watching and documenting every one of their children's milestones.

Incredibly supportive, Defenders make an ideal "home base" for their kids during this stage as well. Their consistency and reliability ensure that their toddlers never feel abandoned, ignored, or unloved. Even though children at this age are incredibly independent, they still crave (and need) trustworthy caregivers that meet all their needs, and Defenders don't disappoint.

Unbalanced Toddler Parenting

Overly-Worried and Overwhelmed

On the flip side, this stage can be especially challenging for Defender parents as they struggle to accept their children's desire to push boundaries. There's a delicate balance to be achieved between providing a safe space to explore and not overly controlling their children's environment. Toddlers who wish to do things independently become increasingly frustrated by parents who continually deny them these opportunities.

Defender parents may tip the scales too far the other direction as well, especially if they have little support from other family members or friends during this stage. Overwhelmed Defenders can become permissive, allowing their children to become dominant and overbearing. Toddlers of permissive parents can become bossy and erratic in their behavior due to a lack of discipline – further overwhelming their already frustrated parents.

Rebalancing Toddler Parenting

Developing Age-Appropriate Boundaries

Children at this stage seek both security and increasing autonomy, and Defender parents tend to need to improve their flexibility to help

promote their children's independence. Testing boundaries is healthy at this stage, and Defenders need to tow the fine line between patiently supporting their toddlers' desires to explore and upholding important rules to ensure safety. Here are some helpful hints Defenders can keep in mind.

- Finding ways to involve toddlers in household chores, or giving them options such as, "Would you like to wear your red shirt or blue shirt today?" can enhance not only their skills but their sense of autonomy and achievement as well.
- On the other hand, little ones who are given too much freedom without firm boundaries during this stage tend to have greater difficulties controlling their emotions and behaviors in the future.
- Defender parents who are too permissive, either due to exhaustion or to avoid confrontation, should seek support from family members, friends, or professionals who can help them.
- Increasing their confidence and enlisting support – from periodic babysitting to help with a bedtime routine – can make an enormous difference for Defenders struggling to uphold boundaries.

Thirst for Knowledge (3–5 Years)

The preschool years, from about three to five years of age, are a prime time for brain development, and children at this stage accumulate knowledge at an extraordinary rate. Preschoolers absorb information like sponges through constant activity and a seemingly infinite amount of questions. Learning at this juncture takes place through play, especially the unstructured kind, and lots of social interaction with family and peers. Creativity is also exercised extensively through imaginary play and make-believe games and stories.

To master this stage, little ones must be given the opportunity to not only make some of their own decisions, but also be allowed to initiate activities, ask questions (and receive answers) and lead others in exploratory play. Children who aren't given these opportunities, or are made to feel as though their constant questions are annoying, can experience feelings of guilt, frustration, and a lack of competence. Consequently, they may suffer from poor self-control or a lack of initiative.

Balanced Preschool Parenting

Incredibly Altruistic

Defenders are natural teachers, and between their altruism and patience, they make educating their children appear effortless. Playing games, engaging in artistic and other creative projects, and practicing letters and numbers are often natural parts of Defender parents' days. They happily answer their preschool children's seemingly ceaseless stream of questions and take great pleasure in modeling practical skills, such as sweeping or washing dishes. Imparting their knowledge in practical, useful ways is one of Defender parents' greatest strengths.

Despite being Introverted, these types often have deep connections with friends, family, and community groups that they're involved with such as clubs, church groups, volunteer groups, or their children's schools. This network of connections can be widely utilized by Defenders to provide both learning and play opportunities for their preschoolers. It's important for these parents that their kids have opportunities to socialize with others, and they can utilize these connections to prioritize both unstructured free play opportunities and more structured experiences like play dates, classes, or sports.

Unbalanced Preschool Parenting

Lacking Flexibility

Although they love promoting learning, Defenders may have difficulty following their children's lead during the preschool years. They may push their kids to achieve educational goals based on unrealistic expectations, such as drilling them on letters, sight words, or math functions before they're ready or able to truly comprehend these concepts. Rather than allowing them to learn organically, Defenders may be tempted to push educational expectations on their little ones – which ultimately leads to frustrations and anger for both parents and preschoolers.

Another area Defender parents may have difficulty with is truly embracing unstructured play. These parents may fall prey to the idea that free play isn't as valuable as "educational" play or structured activities,

and may focus their energy on providing learning experiences rather than allowing their children to take the lead. If they take their love of routine and structure overboard, Defender parents may leave too little room for their preschoolers to make discoveries and even important mistakes that they need to develop competence and initiative.

Rebalancing Preschool Parenting

Increasing Flexibility

Learning to gauge their kids' developmental readiness may be difficult for Defenders who have become too focused on early achievement. Here are some ways Defender parents can focus on allowing them to develop readiness organically.

- Preschoolers don't need an excessive number of classes, "educational" toys and games, or structured learning periods throughout the day. Playing with simple toys allows them to engage with their imagination, the key building block for developing learning abilities.
- Defenders should also take time to participate in play with their children. A game of kickball in the backyard, or sitting on the floor putting puzzles together or playing with toys are all great ways to both model the benefits of play and to enhance the parent-child bond.
- Unstructured play time is of vital importance for children at this stage to gain competence, confidence, and initiative. Defenders must learn to let their children have plenty of free play time without an agenda – ideally with plenty of time outdoors in nature.
- Defender parents can use their routine developing skills to build in time each day for their children to play freely, without structure-specific desired outcomes. Preschoolers who are given these types of freedom gain confidence in their abilities, and may be more inclined to seek educational opportunities later in life.

Creating Competence (5–12 Years)

The early school years are a critical period of skill development for young children. Not only are they still always absorbing new information, but they're also working on becoming proficient in increasingly complex areas, from mathematics to athletics. Children who are both challenged and supported by parents and other caregivers increase their abilities and self-confidence. If they don't receive consistent support, kids at this stage may begin to feel inferior to their peers and may be less likely to work toward achieving long-term goals. If they aren't sufficiently challenged, kids may start to feel overconfident in themselves and their abilities, and may lack modesty and compassion toward others.

Balanced School-Age Parenting

Humble and Encouraging

Striving to be "ideal" students themselves, Defenders tend to promote obedience, attentiveness, and respect for authority in their children as well. The school years, whether spent in a traditional educational environment or not, focus on skills development and obtaining proficiency. Defender parents provide the necessary structure and support to help their kids succeed, whether it's helping with homework, finding tutors, or even just providing consistent encouragement when they become frustrated.

Defenders, while very supportive and encouraging, balance these traits out well with their focus on humility and hard work. They're no strangers to hard work themselves, and can encourage kids of all levels and abilities to achieve their personal best. Defender parents are proud of their children's accomplishments; however, they loathe arrogance and won't hesitate to call out kids engaging in cocky or pretentious behavior. Humility is one of Defenders' greatest values, and it's one that they tend to go to great lengths to promote.

Unbalanced School-Age Parenting

Struggling with Confidence

Defenders may become overly concerned about their children's development and behavior and can quickly overwhelm them with well-intentioned yet unrealistic expectations. This focus on making sure

their sons and daughters are truly "good kids" can prove especially detrimental to children at this stage if it indicates that academic achievement and good behavior are more important than healthy relationships or their personal interests. Defender parents may experience rebellion from their children when they become fed up with an excessive focus on how they appear to others rather than how they feel. Less confident children may struggle to voice their frustration and, instead of rebelling, may become overly dependent on their parents' approval. This may result in difficulty setting their own goals, and can lead to struggling to achieve healthy independence later in life.

Defender parents may also struggle in promoting confidence in their kids. These types tend to work behind the scenes and find themselves less likely to receive recognition for their efforts than more outspoken types. In addition to causing them to feel unappreciated, their desire to avoid conflict prevents Defenders from speaking up or confronting unfair treatment they may receive. Defender parents may, in turn, be unable to provide their children with the necessary tools to improve their own confidence during this sensitive stage.

Rebalancing School-Age Parenting

Constructing Values Together

As much as Defender parents want their children to succeed, it's important that they focus on promoting their kids' overall well-being instead of their own relentless expectations. It's easy to be influenced by society's ideas of success, but Defenders are very devoted to their core values. Using this devotion, they can switch their focus from society's definition to their own holistic idea of what success truly means. Determining and promoting their personal values can help them to guide their children in developing their own values and pursuing their own definitions of a successful life.

This can be a daunting process when there are so many outside factors – such as teachers, peers, and even media sources – telling kids what they should prioritize. Defenders can help encourage and promote their children' confidence in their beliefs by developing a set of

family values, or code of conduct, to help guide their decision-making process. Having these clear boundaries and guidelines, developed with their children's input, provides a foundation for making choices and decisions confidently and constructively.

Finding Thyself (12–18 Years)

During this stage of development, adolescents transition from childhood to adulthood and develop their distinct sense of identity. This transitional period centers around everyone's understanding of what their roles are, both in their relationships and in society. To determine their roles, adolescents in this stage begin the all-important process of identifying their personal values and beliefs. Educational and future career goals may be made, and relationships may be developed, based on how they align with these values and beliefs, making this a pivotal foundational stage that has far-reaching consequences for the rest of their lives.

Balanced Adolescent Parenting

Encouraging Exploration

One of Defender parents' greatest strengths is their unceasing support for their children. During this stage of identity development, teens need their parents' support and understanding more than ever. Defenders tend to be more than willing to assist their kids in the self-discovery process, and are likely to encourage their growth by promoting positive values and providing them with a stable and loving environment.

Regardless of the struggles they may face during this tumultuous time, Defenders remain steadfast in their devotion to their children. This reliability in their affection and their maintenance of daily activities provides a solid foundation for identity-seeking children to venture further into self-discovery while still feeling a sense of stability and love.

Unbalanced Adolescent Parenting

Overly Traditional

Defenders may have difficulty accepting certain aspects of their teenagers' newfound identities during this stage. These types' strong

values often coincide with a preference for "traditional" roles, and kids who push their boundaries too dramatically may both shock and frustrate their Defender parents. The Defender definition of "traditional" doesn't necessarily mean conservative – it tends to mean making sure that things align with their personal and family values. Kids in this stage are trying to figure out if the values and traditions they were raised with truly represent the people they've become. They may challenge or oppose their parents' values in their personal quest, which may frustrate Defenders who feel their deeply-held values are being rejected.

Codependence

The adolescent stage also requires that children become more independent of their parents, making critical life choices on their own and relying less on caregivers for support. Defender parents may struggle with feelings of rejection if they believe their sons and daughters no longer need them or desire their affection. Defenders who identify primarily as parents or caregivers may take the loss of their influence personally. This may result in co-dependent behavior that attempts to prevent their children from becoming more wholly independent.

Rebalancing Adolescent Parenting

Modeling Personal Growth and Understanding

It may prove difficult for Defenders to decrease the amount of control they exert over their teens – not necessarily because they view them as incapable, but because they genuinely believe that they know best. Developing identities separate from their "caretaker" characteristics is important for all parents during this stage, and is even more important for Defenders who may have become too absorbed in their parenting roles. They can take comfort in knowing that their responsibilities and contributions as parents haven't ended. They're just shifting into different forms that are just as important for their children. Here are some things they can keep in mind.

- Understanding is crucial during this stage, which also requires a constant rebalancing of responsibility and expectations as adolescent children become more capable, responsible, and mature.

- Defender parents can practice slowly easing off on their control by providing extended curfews or allowing their teens to use the family car.
- It's also helpful for Defenders at this stage to encourage their kids to privately focus on embracing values that are meaningful to their individual journeys.
- These types can take this opportunity to engage in some self-reflection as well, taking time to rediscover old hobbies, find a club or class to join, or become more involved in a community group or project.

Conclusion

Parenting is one of the most challenging experiences that anyone may face, regardless of their personality type. Defenders have their own unique strengths that can be leveraged to build positive, proactive relationships with their children. There's tremendous potential for personal development that takes place when people become parents, and Defenders can gain much deeper understanding of themselves and others if they use this opportunity to do so.

The advice we've provided here is based on general growth stages for children and primary strengths and weaknesses that many Defenders share. Every child is different, and parents are the best judges of what their children need. The advice here should be used in ways that work best for each family without adding additional stress, frustration, or burden. For special situations, such as behavioral or medical issues, it's best to consult with professional pediatricians or pediatric psychologists to come up with a plan that will work best for everyone involved.

Final Words

Defenders give their all to their relationships. Not everyone can match the energy, attention, dedication, and care that Defenders invest in their connections with other people.

But this doesn't mean that Defenders are doomed to being underappreciated or taken advantage of – far from it. By learning to set appropriate boundaries, speak their own needs, and leave room for self-care, Defenders can create a foundation of balance and equanimity in their relationships. It's true that some people may be tempted to enjoy Defenders' generosity without giving anything in return, but many people will find that their own instincts to give and to help are spurred by Defenders' caring, giving example.

This doesn't mean that every relationship will be perfectly balanced at every moment. At times, Defenders will give more than they receive – and, in most cases, they'll do so freely and happily. This personality type's dedication to helping others is among their greatest gifts, and it would be a loss for everyone if Defenders curtailed their instinct to step in and be of service. That said, if the imbalance stretches for too long, Defenders will ideally recognize and address the situation rather than allowing themselves to become exhausted or resentful.

In these pages, we've discussed how Defenders can enhance their romantic relationships, their friendships, and their relationships with their children. Of course, because relationships involve multiple people, no one person can "fix" them on their own – not even if that person is as dedicated as a Defender. Our hope is that, by drawing on the insights in these pages, Defenders can gain a better understanding of not only how they can meet other people's needs but also how they can ensure that their own needs aren't neglected. Ultimately, this gives Defenders an even greater reserve of energy, care, inspiration, and goodwill to share with the people who matter to them.

So... What's Next?

You've reached the end of this book, but fear not – we've created many more resources for you. Here are a few that might capture your interest:

- Want more tests and insights to help you direct your personal growth journey? Explore our Relationships Tools and Assessments.
- Looking to enhance your academic or professional life? Check out the *Defender Guide to Careers*.
- Ready to build a strong foundation for your self-development? Our *Defender Guide to Personal Growth* may be just what you need.

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